

Grade-9

UNIT-1

UNDERSTANDING DEMOCRACY

1. Meaning of Democracy

- Democracy is one of the most popular forms of government.
- The word Democracy comes from the Greek word "**Demokratia.**"
 - Demos = People
 - Kratos = Power
- Democracy means **Rule by the People.**
- In a democracy, rulers are elected by the people.
- Abraham Lincoln defined democracy as:
"Government of the people, by the people, for the people."

2. What Constitutes the People?

- In ancient Athens, voting rights were limited.
- Women, slaves and foreigners could not vote.
- Modern democracy believes in **Universal Adult Franchise.**
- Every adult citizen has the right to vote without discrimination.
- All citizens are equal before the law.

3. Roots of Democracy in India

Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam

- Means "**The World is One Family.**"
- Promotes equality, cooperation and respect.

Sabha and Samiti

- Important assemblies during the Vedic Period.
- Discussed public issues.
- Advised the king in governance.

Ancient Republics (Gana-Sanghas)

- Existed between 600 BCE and 400 BCE.
- Decisions were taken collectively.

Village Panchayats

- Managed local administration.
- Solved disputes and delivered justice.
- Encouraged people's participation.

Contribution to Modern Democracy

- Participation of people.
- Local self-government.
- Decision-making through discussion and consensus.

4. Features of Democracy

1. Free and Fair Elections

- Citizens choose their representatives through elections.

2. Universal Adult Franchise

- Every adult citizen has the right to vote.

3. Rule of Law

- Everyone is equal before the law.

4. Fundamental Rights

- Citizens enjoy constitutional rights.

5. Freedom of Speech and Expression

- Citizens can express opinions freely.

6. Freedom to Form Associations

- Citizens can form unions, organizations and political parties.

7. Accountability of Government

- Government is answerable to the people.

8. Right to Information (RTI)

- Citizens can obtain information from public authorities.
- RTI Act came into force in 2005.

5. Types of Democracy

A. Direct Democracy

- Citizens directly participate in decision-making.
- Practiced in Ancient Athens.
- Suitable for small populations.

B. Representative Democracy

- Citizens elect representatives.
- Representatives govern on behalf of the people.
- Followed by most modern countries.

6. Parliamentary Democracy

- Executive is responsible to the legislature.
- Prime Minister is the real executive head.
- Government remains in power only if it enjoys majority support.
- Example: India, United Kingdom.

Features

- Close relationship between executive and legislature.
- Collective responsibility.
- Flexible system.

7. Presidential Democracy

- Executive and legislature are separate.
- President is both Head of State and Head of Government.
- President is elected independently.
- Example: United States of America.

Features

- Separation of powers.
- Fixed tenure.

- Independent executive.

8. Democratic System in the World

Dictatorship vs Democracy

The chapter discusses dictators such as:

- Adolf Hitler
- Benito Mussolini
- Saddam Hussein
- Idi Amin

Spread of Democracy

Three major events helped democracy spread worldwide:

(i) Second World War

- Defeat of fascist governments.

(ii) Decolonisation

- Colonies became independent nations.
- Many adopted democracy.

(iii) Collapse of the Soviet Union

- Many countries moved towards democratic systems.

Importance of Democracy

- Equality of citizens.
- Participation in governance.
- Protection of rights.
- Accountability of government.

9. Challenges to Democracy in India

- Corruption.
- Poverty.
- Illiteracy.
- Social inequality.
- Criminalization of politics.

- Lack of political awareness.
- Misuse of power.
- Low public participation.

IMPORTANT QUESTION ANSWERS

Q1. What is democracy?

Answer: Democracy is a form of government in which rulers are elected by the people.

Q2. What is the meaning of democracy?

Answer: Democracy means rule by the people. It comes from the Greek words Demos (people) and Kratos (power).

Q3. Who defined democracy as "government of the people, by the people, for the people"?

Answer: Abraham Lincoln.

Q4. What is Universal Adult Franchise?

Answer: It is the right of every adult citizen to vote without discrimination.

Q5. What does Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam mean?

Answer: It means "The World is One Family."

Q6. What were Sabha and Samiti?

Answer: They were assemblies in the Vedic period that discussed public matters and advised the king.

Q7. What are Gana-Sanghas?

Answer: Ancient Indian republics where decisions were taken collectively.

Q8. Mention any four features of democracy.

Answer:

1. Free and fair elections
2. Rule of law

3. Fundamental rights
4. Accountability of government

Q9. What is Direct Democracy?

Answer: A system in which citizens directly participate in decision-making.

Q10. What is Representative Democracy?

Answer: A system in which citizens elect representatives to govern on their behalf.

Q11. What is Parliamentary Democracy?

Answer: A system in which the executive is responsible to the legislature.

Q12. Give two examples of Parliamentary Democracy.

Answer: India and the United Kingdom.

Q13. What is Presidential Democracy?

Answer: A system in which the President is the real executive and is independent of the legislature.

Q14. Give one example of Presidential Democracy.

Answer: United States of America.

Q15. Name three events that helped spread democracy.

Answer:

1. Second World War
2. Decolonisation
3. Collapse of the Soviet Union

Q16. Why is democracy important?

Answer: Democracy ensures equality, participation, protection of rights and accountable government.

Q17. Mention any four challenges to democracy in India.

Answer:

1. Corruption
2. Poverty
3. Illiteracy
4. Social inequality

Long Answer Questions:

Q1. Define Democracy and Explain its Main Features.

Answer:

Democracy is a form of government in which the rulers are elected by the people. The word democracy is derived from the Greek word *Demokratia*, where *Demos* means "people" and *Kratos* means "power." Therefore, democracy means "rule by the people." Abraham Lincoln defined democracy as "**Government of the people, by the people, for the people.**"

Democracy is considered the most popular form of government because it gives power to the citizens and protects their rights.

Main Features of Democracy

1. Free and Fair Elections

In a democracy, people choose their representatives through regular elections. Elections must be conducted fairly so that every candidate gets an equal opportunity to contest and every voter can vote freely.

2. Universal Adult Franchise

Every adult citizen has the right to vote without discrimination based on caste, religion, gender, language, race or economic status. In India, all citizens aged 18 years and above have voting rights.

3. Rule of Law

The law is supreme in a democracy. Everyone, including government officials, is equal before the law and must obey it.

4. Fundamental Rights

Citizens enjoy various rights such as the right to equality, freedom, education and constitutional remedies.

5. Freedom of Speech and Expression

People can express their opinions, criticize government policies and participate in public discussions without fear.

6. Accountability of Government

The government is answerable to the people. If it fails to perform well, citizens can replace it through elections.

7. Citizen Participation

Citizens participate in governance by voting, discussing public issues and contributing to decision-making processes.

Thus, democracy ensures freedom, equality, justice and participation of people in governance.

Q2. Explain the Roots of Democracy in India.

Answer:

The roots of democracy in India are very ancient. Long before modern democratic governments were established, India had traditions and institutions that encouraged people's participation in governance.

1. Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam

Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam means "**The World is One Family.**" This idea teaches equality, brotherhood, cooperation and respect for all human beings. It reflects democratic values of equality and inclusiveness.

2. Sabha and Samiti

During the Vedic period, Sabha and Samiti were important assemblies. They discussed public matters, advised kings and participated in governance. These institutions allowed people to express their opinions.

3. Gana-Sanghas

Ancient Indian republics known as Gana-Sanghas existed between 600 BCE and 400 BCE. Decisions were taken collectively rather than by a single ruler. This practice reflected democratic decision-making.

4. Village Panchayats

Village Panchayats managed local administration, settled disputes and maintained law and order. They promoted self-governance and public participation.

Contribution to Modern Democracy

These ancient institutions contributed several democratic principles:

- People's participation in governance
- Equality among citizens
- Collective decision-making
- Local self-government
- Discussion and consensus building

Therefore, India's democratic traditions have deep historical roots that continue to influence modern democracy.

Q3. Explain the Concept of Universal Adult Franchise.

Answer:

Universal Adult Franchise is one of the most important features of democracy. It means that every adult citizen has the right to vote regardless of caste, religion, gender, language, race, education or economic status.

In ancient democracies such as Athens, voting rights were limited. Women, slaves and foreigners were not allowed to vote. As a result, democracy was restricted to a small section of society.

Modern democracies believe in equality and non-discrimination. Therefore, all adult citizens are given equal voting rights.

Universal Adult Franchise in India

India adopted Universal Adult Franchise at the time of independence. Every citizen who is 18 years of age or above can vote in elections.

Importance of Universal Adult Franchise

1. Ensures equality among citizens.
2. Gives every citizen a voice in government.
3. Strengthens democracy.
4. Prevents discrimination.
5. Makes governments accountable to all sections of society.
6. Encourages public participation.

Thus, Universal Adult Franchise ensures that democracy truly reflects the will of the people.

Q4. Differentiate Between Direct Democracy and Representative Democracy.

Answer:

Democracy can be broadly divided into Direct Democracy and Representative Democracy.

Direct Democracy

Direct Democracy is a system in which citizens directly participate in making laws and decisions. People themselves discuss issues and vote on policies.

Features:

- Citizens make decisions directly.
- Suitable for small populations.
- Greater public participation.
- Practiced in Ancient Athens.

Representative Democracy

Representative Democracy is a system in which people elect representatives to govern on their behalf. The elected representatives make laws and policies.

Features:

- Citizens elect representatives.
- Suitable for large populations.
- Practical and efficient.
- Followed by most modern countries.

Comparison

Direct Democracy

Representative Democracy

Citizens make decisions directly. Representatives make decisions.

Suitable for small populations. Suitable for large populations.

High direct participation. Indirect participation.

Example: Ancient Athens. Example: India.

Today, most countries follow Representative Democracy because it is difficult for millions of citizens to participate directly in governance.

Q5. Explain Parliamentary Democracy and its Features.

Answer:

Parliamentary Democracy is a form of government in which the executive derives its authority from the legislature and remains accountable to it.

India follows a Parliamentary system of government. In this system, the Prime Minister is the real executive head, while the President is the constitutional head.

Features of Parliamentary Democracy

1. Executive Responsible to Legislature

The Council of Ministers is answerable to Parliament for its actions and decisions.

2. Prime Minister as Real Executive

The Prime Minister leads the government and exercises executive powers.

3. Collective Responsibility

All ministers are collectively responsible to Parliament for government decisions.

4. Majority Support

The government remains in power only as long as it enjoys majority support in Parliament.

5. Close Relationship Between Executive and Legislature

Members of the executive are usually members of the legislature.

Advantages

- Promotes accountability.
- Encourages cooperation.
- Provides flexibility in governance.
- Allows quick removal of ineffective governments.

India and the United Kingdom are examples of Parliamentary Democracy.

Q6. Explain Presidential Democracy and its Features.

Answer:

Presidential Democracy is a system of government in which the President is both the Head of State and Head of Government.

The President is elected separately from the legislature and exercises executive powers independently.

The United States of America follows the Presidential system.

Features of Presidential Democracy

1. Separation of Powers

Executive, legislature and judiciary function independently.

2. President as Real Executive

The President is responsible for administration and policy implementation.

3. Fixed Tenure

The President serves for a fixed term and cannot be removed easily.

4. Independent Executive

The executive does not depend on legislative support for survival.

5. Stability

Fixed tenure provides continuity and stability in government.

Advantages

- Strong leadership.
- Stable government.
- Clear separation of powers.
- Independent functioning of institutions.

Thus, Presidential Democracy ensures stability and efficient administration.

Q7. Compare Parliamentary Democracy and Presidential Democracy.

Answer:

Parliamentary and Presidential democracies are two important forms of representative government.

Parliamentary Democracy

Prime Minister is the real executive.

Executive is accountable to legislature.

Flexible tenure.

Executive and legislature are closely linked.

Government can fall through a no-confidence motion.

Example: India, UK.

Presidential Democracy

President is the real executive.

Executive is independent of legislature.

Fixed tenure.

Separation of powers exists.

President remains in office for fixed term.

Example: USA.

Similarities

- Both are democratic systems.
- Both protect citizens' rights.
- Both conduct elections.
- Both encourage people's participation.

Although both systems are democratic, they differ in the relationship between the executive and the legislature.

Q8. Explain the Democratic System in the World.

Answer:

Democracy is now one of the most widely accepted forms of government in the world. However, many countries were once ruled by dictators who exercised absolute power.

Famous Dictators

- Adolf Hitler (Germany)
- Benito Mussolini (Italy)
- Saddam Hussein (Iraq)
- Idi Amin (Uganda)

Spread of Democracy

1. Second World War

The defeat of fascist governments during World War II encouraged the growth of democratic governments.

2. Decolonisation

After independence, many former colonies adopted democratic constitutions and governments.

3. Collapse of the Soviet Union

The collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 encouraged many countries to embrace democracy.

Importance of Democracy

- Protects human rights.
- Promotes equality.
- Ensures citizen participation.
- Maintains accountability.
- Encourages peaceful transfer of power.

Today democracy is regarded as the most effective system for protecting the interests of citizens.

Q9. Why is Democracy Considered the Best Form of Government?

Answer:

Democracy is considered the best form of government because it promotes freedom, equality, justice and public participation.

Reasons

1. Government Chosen by the People

Citizens elect their representatives through free and fair elections.

2. Accountability

The government remains answerable to citizens for its actions.

3. Protection of Rights

Democracy protects fundamental rights and freedoms.

4. Freedom of Expression

People can freely express opinions and criticize the government.

5. Equality Before Law

All citizens are treated equally under the law.

6. Citizen Participation

People participate in governance through voting and public discussions.

7. Peaceful Transfer of Power

Governments change through elections rather than violence.

8. Welfare of People

Government policies are generally aimed at improving citizens' lives.

Because of these advantages, democracy is regarded as the most effective and people-friendly form of government.

Q10. Discuss the Challenges to Democracy in India.

Answer:

India is the world's largest democracy, but it faces several challenges that affect its smooth functioning.

1. Corruption

Corruption reduces public trust and diverts resources meant for development.

2. Poverty

Poor citizens may struggle to participate fully in democratic processes.

3. Illiteracy

Lack of education reduces political awareness and informed decision-making.

4. Social Inequality

Discrimination based on caste, gender and economic status affects equality.

5. Criminalization of Politics

People with criminal backgrounds sometimes enter politics and influence governance negatively.

6. Misuse of Power

Political leaders may misuse authority for personal or political gain.

7. Lack of Political Awareness

Many citizens are unaware of their rights and responsibilities.

8. Low Public Participation

Some citizens do not actively participate in elections and civic activities.

Measures to Strengthen Democracy

- Improve education and literacy.
- Create political awareness.
- Reduce corruption.
- Promote social equality.
- Encourage citizen participation.
- Ensure transparency and accountability.

By overcoming these challenges, India can further strengthen its democratic system and ensure better governance for all citizens.